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Glenn Zottola

Multi-instrumentalist Glenn Zottola has enjoyed a diverse career in music that includes collaborations with Bob Wilber, Benny Goodman, and Maxine Sullivan. For nine years, Glenn excelled in the role of Suzanne Somer's musical director.

Glenn was interviewed on December 7, 2020 via Zoom by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Glenn Zottola here for a session. And we were just talking about how many memories you have and I've been toiling over my first question.

GZ: Okay.

MR: Because you've done quite a bit. So I've never done this before, okay?

GZ: Good. I like that.

MR: We're going to start —

GZ: We're going to improvise, yeah.

MR: We're going to start with name this tune:

GZ: Okay.

MR: Okay. You have to —

GZ: This is a Leonard Feather blindfold test.

MR: Yeah. You'll have to forgive my synthesized trumpet here.

GZ: Okay.

MR: Okay here we go.

[audio interlude]

GZ: I've got a story for you on that. "My Red Robin." That's "My Red Robin." That is my first solo that I played in second grade. Here's the story, in front of the entire school my mother played like Count Basie, she was my accompanist. So I played that tune in second grade and I was nervous and I went blank on the bridge. And I ran off stage crying. And then my mother came to me and gave me a pep talk and I came back on and finished it to a standing ovation. And it goes to show you a little encouragement early on goes a long way.

MR: You know I thought about that because —

GZ: Why did you pick that tune?

MR: Well because — no I read it.

GZ: Oh. Okay. I said this guy's clairvoyant.

MR: It struck a nerve with me because when I was in fourth grade I was playing the flutephone, which is like a recorder. And I did pretty well and my tune was "The Marine's Hymn." So, but not quite as sophisticated as — I mean that "Red Red Robin" has a [scats] it's like a tricky bridge for a second grader.

GZ: Well they played it on jazz gigs in the old days, you know, yeah.

MR: Yeah. And then the next thing I know I'm seeing you on the "Ted Mack Amateur Hour" sounding like you're 35 years old.

GZ: Okay. That was all Louie's my first mentor. My dad knew him.

MR: Yeah. It's very curious that you say that because I don't know if you put that in my head in reading some of the material about you but I could hear that in your time.

GZ: You know you nailed it because let me tell you something. Everything I've done in my life, and I have a pretty wide scope of music from Louis to Charlie Parker, Miles — it all, the foundation of all of it is Louis' time. And not just for me. I heard an interview from a documentary of Bing Crosby. And Bing said me, I wouldn't be here and Sinatra wouldn't be here if it wasn't for Louis. And I did a gig with, oh my God, the saxophone player who, from the 20s was in the Paul Whiteman band, you would know him, he was the kind of —

MR: Al Gallodoro?

GZ: Before, no before Lester Young, Bud Freeman.

MR: Oh Bud, yeah.

GZ: And Bud told me when Louis first came to Chicago, me and Bix Beiderbecke used to go down and to hear this new guy in town. And when we first went there we couldn't deal with it. We couldn't understand what the hell he was doing with the time. We never heard anyone lay back like that. Because you know jazz of the 20s was very on top of the beat. So when Louis came in with the New Orleans, King Oliver type time, they couldn't understand it. He said we went back several times and we finally got to love it. So you bring up a great point. Because Louis' time, I mean none of us would be here — Miles, I don't care who. He set the standard not only for musicians but for vocalists too.

MR: If someone could, maybe people have done this, sometimes you see a printout of sound waves. You know, the drum, you hit the snare drum and it goes like this. It's almost like a cardiac chart. And I'm wondering where Louis Armstrong placed his quarter notes in relationship to the beat.

GZ: Well behind, for sure, laid back, behind, not on top. You know. You could probably measure it but I'm just saying it was behind.

MR: Right. Okay.

GZ: And it became the jazz feel you know, at least in the black world anyway.

MR: Yeah. It's funny how that playing —

GZ: My complaint — let me just tell you my complaint about jazz today — to some degree, and they are great players these guys, they have lost the very thing we're talking about. That time. That groove. That swing. All the guys playing with Ray Brown. All the guys I came up with — Milt Hinton — that's what they loved about me because I absorbed that when I was a kid. I was listening to Louis' records you know.

MR: Does a person who's teaching jazz, are they able to put that into words?

GZ: It's hard.

MR: "You're not swinging." "Okay well if I'm not swinging how to I swing then?"

GZ: It's hard. I mean you take a chart, and I've played in all the big bands you know. I remember doing Sinatra, playing with Sinatra and Snooky Young's playing lead trumpet. And I'm playing next to him. I said oh my God, he's playing these Nelson Riddle charts like nobody else. It was like being in a small quintet, Count Basie's band but he's playing Nelson Riddle charts with Sinatra. It was an awakening for me to hear him play lead with his concept as opposed to other great players who I played with — I played with Doc Severinsen you know.

MR: Bobby Shew just talked about that.

GZ: Okay.

MR: About Snooky Young and —

GZ: Is Bobby still alive?

MR: Yes he is, he's doing all right.

GZ: I knew he was ill you know. Okay.

MR: So let me ask you if there was — you know you were surrounded by music, your parents had a jazz club, was there ever a question in your head about how you were going to make a living?

GZ: Never. Well since my whole family was musicians, the phone kind of started ringing after television. You know I didn't have to go out and hustle up gigs. So I was fortunate in that way. No I never had any thought of that, I just followed my heart you know.

MR: Do you remember the first paying gig you ever had and how much you made?

GZ: Yeah. I was doing the Chubby — you know Chubby Jackson, right?

MR: Yes.

GZ: So I did a lot of performances on the "Little Rascals Show." Okay? And you know they had a big band on that show with Don Lamond was on drums, they had a fantastic band. So Chubby hooked me up with his son, Duffy, and we started a little group together with Duffy. And then he got me a gig, my first big gig at eleven years old guesting with Bobby Hackett and Jack Teagarden. So I think that was my first big gig.

MR: And what did you make?

GZ: I don't know. But we went to a diner afterwards and hung out with Jack and Bobby, you know.

MR: You see you can't separate —

GZ: How do you buy that?

MR: Yes you can't buy that and you can't separate it from the music, that fraternity and those like being around those guys.

GZ: I just told a friend of mine whom, actually I never teached in my whole life, never wanted to, but I'm helping a friend. And I said one of the things I love about the bandstand and where I came up, you get on the bandstand and either you can play and you can swing or you can't. And you can't say anything, no P.R., no hype will get you out of it. It's a level playing field, okay? And it's a beautiful thing, because there is no bullshit that will help you, it won't. And I came up that way, playing with legends who took me under their wing and allowed me to flourish and blossom because they saw some talent there. But that's a different world than the music school of today, right?

MR: Yes.

GZ: It's apprenticeship, the old school of apprenticeship.

MR: Yeah. And I've had people, I remember Eddie Locke saying he described what you just said about the mentors, but one thing he said that sounded important is they never bullshitted him about, "Oh you're the greatest thing ever."

GZ: Right.

MR: They just would say, "Yeah, yeah, you're doing good, keep it up," and they were encouraging but not over the top.

GZ: Right. Well for example when Miles joined Charlie Parker, he could hardly play with them compared to Dizzy and Fats Navarro. As a trumpet player he was very weak. But I guess Bird saw something in his communication or the way his style was that he saw promise there. And that's the other thing I cherish about the black cats that I owe my life to. They gave you a lot of headway. If they saw something that was good they allowed it to develop, rather than more like you know I hate to say this in the white world you know you hit a wrong note and they slam you for that. It wasn't that approach. They see something that there's promise there and they grant you the ability to let that blossom and they encourage you and help you.

MR: As a young man going into these clubs and playing with these gentlemen, was there ever any uncomfortable situations as far as the racial end of things?

GZ: I never got one ounce of any racial bullshit. Nothing. Zero. Because I could play and I could swing and they saw I had a love for Louis and they could see the promise there. They didn't care. They did not care about race. They cared only about one thing: the music.

MR: Let me ask you a question before I forget it. You said you had perfect pitch as a kid.

GZ: Yeah.

MR: I don't have it. And I'm wondering —

GZ: You don't have to. I mean a lot of guys that are amazing don't have it you know.

MR: Yeah. But I'm wondering how does it work when you're playing, I mean you play the alto sax and tenor and trumpet so with a concert pitch you've got potentially three things going. If you're playing an E flat horn you're not, the notes you're playing on the sax are not concert pitch. So does this cause some kind of scrambling in your brain?

GZ: It's a good question. Realize something, okay? I know nothing about chords and I have no awareness of what key I'm playing in. Okay? So it's all here. I'm hearing the music. Now if, sometimes I remember in the beginning when I had switched to alto and then to go tenor or trumpet, going to the E flat there might be, because I'm pressing down a C, right, on the alto. And for perfect pitch it's not the C I'm used to on a B flat instrument. Right? So there was a little adjustment there, but then I just started thinking about it and used my ears. Relative, you know.

MR: Yeah. Did you ever feel compelled — I'm trying to phrase this question — in different musical situations that man I ought to learn some theory?

GZ: You know I wanted to when I was a kid. I went to — I almost failed it, I went to a theory course in high school and I was going crazy. I went to my dad and I said, 'cause they were teaching stationary Do. No they were teaching Movable Do.

MR: Movable Do. Okay.

GZ: Yeah. My dad started me off on solfeggio [claps] you know. So to me a C is a C carved in stone. And they were trying to teach me chords where the root was this and it's not a C anymore, and with the perfect pitch I was going crazy with that. So I went to a friend of mine, a really good jazz pianist and I said you know, "I really want to learn theory and I'm having a lot of trouble." And he said, "Let me just tell you something, you're already playing all these changes, don't do it, it's going to ruin your playing." That was his advice. I mean not great advice but that's what he — "you're already playing all this stuff." I said, "Yeah but I'd like to know what a minor seventh is, whatever that is." He said, "You're already playing minor sevenths." You know.

MR: Yes. "I feel as though I have to call it something."

GZ: Yeah, right, right, right. I was talking to Chick Corea about that because you know he's very knowledgeable, you know.

MR: Yeah. Well I have a Chick Corea question for later but we haven't got there yet.

GZ: Yeah, yeah.

MR: So all these opportunities were coming your way and this is sort of a follow-up to the question about choosing a career.

GZ: Before that, let me tell you, the next step after the Jack Teagarden/Bobby Hackett gig, my next big gig was when I was 13, the Atlantic City Jazz Festival. I was in a high school jazz band. I was only in grammar school or junior high and I was a lead trumpet and a jazz trumpet, and I went to this jazz band. Anyway I did the Atlantic City Jazz Festival on the bill with Dinah Washington, Gerry Mulligan, Oscar Peterson Trio, and Art Blakey. And I was 13. Yeah.

MR: You were 13?

GZ: I was 13, yeah.

MR: Well it sort of impacts my question here, because I remember when I was in high school and then music school, the circle of musician friends, we wanted to make it in the music business. And I can remember using that term. Oh we want to make it.

GZ: That's a term that all the guys, young guys today, especially in the pop world, they haven't even had a gig and they want to make it.

MR: Yeah. So I wonder if you had that feeling. You might not have used that term.

GZ: The reverse. The reverse.

MR: Really? Explain.

GZ: I would get together every week jamming, guys a lot older than me, all the black cats in my neighborhood. And we'd get together and we'd jam with no thought of a gig, just to get together and play. Have a good time. There was never any thought of being famous or get a gig or whatever you know.

MR: What was your neighborhood?

GZ: I grew up in a place called Port Chester, New York, near Connecticut, and this was in the Yonkers area where Ahmad Jamal lives. And there was a bunch of black guys, older. They were good players, they were beboppers and you know, they weren't famous or anything. And we'd get together every week and I was only maybe 15, 14 years old. Just to play.

MR: And if they played a tune, let's say you went to one session and they called "How High the Moon" and you didn't know it. How did you learn it for next time?

GZ: Well I was fortunate. When I was five years old my mom, she played by ear also, she sat me on her knee at the piano and she taught me hundreds of standards without a sheet of music. Hundreds. Okay?

MR: Can you explain how and what she was teaching you? Did you have the trumpet?

GZ: Yeah. She would comp the changes and sing, and it's in my DNA. I learned all those standards without a sheet of music, by ear. And then I would, every time I'd come home from school since I was little, grammar school, we would jam every day. Piano and trumpet.

MR: And years later if you were playing with like a female vocalist who did all those tunes in different keys? It didn't matter?

GZ: No. I knew them. I knew them. I mean the American Songbook is in my DNA. I never really, I'm just starting to do some of Chick Corea's music, which is not my thing. My whole life is Rogers & Hart and Irving Berlin and Cole Porter. You know that's my life, as a lot of jazz players from the era we're talking about, right? Very few guys wrote their own material then.

MR: Okay. Did you get a sense, eventually, that playing music for a living can be challenging, from a perhaps paying your rent aspect? Supporting a family?

GZ: Yeah. I never really thought about it and I never struggled. I mean you know it wasn't like I was in affluence all the time either. But I never struggled to pay the rent and to live and to raise a family. The phone rang and it would escalate. In other words I'd get a call from Bob Wilber, next thing you know I'm touring for six years with him in Europe, next thing you know I meet Suzanne Somers and she says I want you as my band leader, and that's a whole story in itself. I left the jazz world as we know it, to go to Hollywood. And because of that I don't have to make a living from music now. I saw there was a ceiling, Monk, to what we do. I saw all the guys out there, all the legends that I admired — I'm not going to mention their names — in their 70s and 80s, because they needed the work they were playing with half their chops and half — not the quality rhythm sections that they were — I mean how do you replace Count Basie's All-American Rhythm Section? Hard, when you've been in the Basie band, or Woody Herman's band, or whatever. So I saw them out there, even Ella — she was out there working for George Wein doing one-nighters in Europe.

MR: I noticed the same thing when I started doing these interviews and it shocked me at first and then it didn't shock me anymore, and that is when a person that I was interviewing who was like a hero of mine, someone that I'd followed for decades, and at the end of the interview they would, well, hit me up for a gig.

GZ: Yeah.

MR: And I started to realize, well why should I assume that these gentlemen have it made, that they don't have to work anymore.

GZ: They don't. You don't. Sonny Rollins did a great interview, he says, "If you want to be a jazz musician" now he did very well, Sonny, but he's saying, "Listen, you don't do this for money. This is a spiritual thing" he says. So I mean I remember hiring Lou Donaldson years ago for a series at a five star hotel and I did a jazz series, and I hired Lou Donaldson, just one time. Twenty years later I'm doing the Clearwater Jazz Festival, on the bill, and Lou was on the bill. I'm backstage ready to go on and he comes up to me. This is twenty years later. "How come you don't call on me anymore for a gig." I said,

"Lou that was twenty years ago." So yeah, I told my press agent when I was in Europe, when I was only maybe 40 years old, this was before I joined Suzanne Somers, I said listen — and I'm not going to mention any names — I'm playing with these guys and I'm looking at them in their 70s and 80s doing one-nighters in Europe. And I said to him, he said, he reminds me. I remember what you said to me, I said I never want to end up like that.

MR: I see.

GZ: And that's why I joined Suzanne. And I loved it anyway, musically. But I joined her because I saw there was a ceiling. And all my friends are still doing it: Scott Hamilton, Ken Peplowski, Butch doesn't play anymore, but all the guys are still — and they love it and they're great grinding it out for I don't know how much per night you know. And now with the virus they're all oh my God.

MR: Yeah. Yeah it's a whole other ballgame now. Let's talk about —

GZ: I don't know if I'm answering your questions. You've got me — I'm passionate about what you're asking you know.

MR: Yeah. When you took on that Suzanne Somers gig, now here you are you're a self-professed ear player, and I'm going to guess that those — that that kind of gig, you're required to provide different kinds of accompaniment for different kinds of musical settings, and in a hurry.

GZ: She was special. She loved me, she loved the music. In seven years together she only said one thing to me, which is very unusual for a celebrity: "Just do your Glenn thing." That's the only thing she ever told me. I improvised her show entirely different every night.

MR: Really?

GZ: Yeah. I improvised a TV show with no music, eight shows a week. I ran it like a jazz gig.

MR: You must have —

GZ: We're ready to go into commercial break and my bass player taps me on the shoulder, "Glenn do you know what we're playing next?" I said give me about 30 seconds I'll let you know.

MR: Wow. You had to be on your game. And I guess you had a good supporting cast of free-wheeling musicians.

GZ: Yeah. And I loved it. I loved it. You know I'm a jazz player. I would never be there if it wasn't for Suzanne. I'm not a TV guy you know. But you know she loved it and I made her, you know she is a very successful actress but I made her life come true with what I brought to her act.

MR: Okay so you got immersed in W-9s and paperwork and like almost like a real job but you were still a musician.

GZ: I had a big office next to Steven Spielberg in Universal Studios with a big practice room and I had a golf cart to go to the show every morning to record, you know. I thought I died and went to heaven, believe me. Because previous I'm on the road doing one-nighters you know. I landed in Heathrow Airport, someone's supposed to pick me up, they're not there, I've got to find my way to the gig. Now I'm ten minutes from my house to Universal Studios. I've got the golf cart, I've got the office, I mean this was like forget it. More money than I ever dreamed was possible to make in music, you know. Playing for tens, hundreds of millions of people every time I got onstage, and I could feel it, I could feel that magnitude of the audience, you know even pop stars don't experience that. So it was another world. I loved it, truly loved it. A different celebrity every show.

MR: Your mentioning going to Heathrow and, I'm guessing you did a certain amount of showing up and playing with a local rhythm section?

GZ: Exactly. Who — I mean you'd have to be — not everybody could afford to bring a band over from the U.S. you know. And some of those guys were great, in England.

MR: What do you do to make that as workable as possible — showing up as a soloist. Did you have a list of tunes and go through it with the group and say, "Okay everybody okay with this tune, that tune."

GZ: Well I'm a pretty unrehearsed guy. I'm a first — one-take unrehearsed guy anyway. So I liked it. I'm a jam session type guy, you know, I'm not — Chick, working with Chick is another world. He is so precise on what he wants. You know what I mean? There's nothing wrong with that, but I come from a different school. I come from a jam session school. You know.

MR: Yeah. I was listening to your duet with him, "Skylark."

GZ: Yeah.

MR: And I was putting myself in your place and I'm sure you know the tune. But you may not know Chick's version of "Skylark."

GZ: Exactly.

MR: So what does that do to your musical choices?

GZ: You know it's funny, we're working on "Crystal Silence." I don't know if you know that song.

MR: I do know that song, yeah.

GZ: So he sent me a demo and I played it, and he said, "Uh well bar 54, all right, did enough takes. So I did like twelve takes on this thing, right? And I'm ready to say Chick listen, I love you but I'm out of here. I've never took twelve takes on anything. So I went over his house and he sat down with me at the piano and he said, "Oh I see what's happening, you don't understand, this is double time, I'm playing double time, and the music's not written that way, it's my mistake, I'm so sorry, I'll re-write it. And as soon as he said that

to me I understood what he was talking about, because he's saying you know bar 54 you're a bar ahead of me. I said, "What?" Because I'm using my ears and I'm playing it for other people, they love it. And I realize now he's right because he's playing in half time, double time, whatever that is. But I'm just saying he is very particular, especially about his own music but any music he plays. He's like really precise.

MR: Does your ear, how do I say this, do you feel your ear is capable of dealing with some of his most hip changes?

GZ: Yeah and you know as far as the changes, his tunes are very difficult for me. They're more like a Michael Brecker type player, okay? But as far as his changes, I can definitely work around his changes. It's different than Tommy Flanagan, you know what I mean?

MR: Yeah.

GZ: But I love it because it's interesting and I use my ears but I can work around his changes and they're fantastic. They give me new directions to go. So I don't have a problem with that. His written music is a problem though. It requires a tremendous amount of precision, which I am not that kind of player.

MR: Yeah I can recall seeing him in I guess it was the early 70s when he had this "Return to Forever" like, high-impact jazz fusion. And he's quite a guy.

GZ: Yeah, listen he changed the jazz world along with, what's the other band Wayne Shorter was in?

MR: Weather Report. Joe Zawinul.

GZ: That kind of music was one of the reasons I decided to join Bob Wilber. I was like at the peak of my bebop era when that music started to come in, electronic. And I went, instead of moving forward I went back. I said let me go back to Louis. Because I didn't see any place to go with that music. You know? It was so loud oh my God.

MR: Yeah and it didn't have much to do with the trumpet.

GZ: Or a horn player you know.

MR: Horn player, yeah. Like you said if you're Michael Brecker you could find your way in that music, but I know what you're saying.

GZ: You know Michael Brecker hurt himself real bad.

MR: Oh.

GZ: He did. That's why he had to get the whole new mouthpiece and Guardala. He blew out something in his neck. Serious.

MR: Wow.

GZ: Yeah. It's not a horn player thing you know, that music.

MR: Well I also love, along with Chick I watched you play on the video with Bob Wilber. And he was a friend of Hamilton College too. He received an honorary degree from our

school and I loved the sort of obbligato stuff he was playing behind you. And I don't really have a question here except that —

GZ: Quite a musician, huh?

MR: Yeah. And I think it's really cool that you play by ear but you also know some of those standard licks that went with those particular songs. Like "China Boy" and all that.

GZ: Yeah well Lou, I mean Bob was heavy into Louis, right? And when I joined him he was in heaven because I come out of the Louis mold and he loved that with Bechet and everything like that. So all those licks that were developed, they all come from Bechet and Louis, you know, all that stuff anyway. I was good friends with Ruby. He loved my playing you know because we both had a love for Louis you know. Ruby is a wild character, man. Did you interview him?

MR: I tried. That's like a story I might have to tell off-camera.

GZ: He goes into a five star hotel, he gets on stage and they're all having dinner you know, upscale place. And he opens up the gig by saying, "I'm going to play some jazz, you eat your dinner. You don't bother me and I won't bother you."

MR: Oh God.

GZ: He comes off, I mean can I swear on this?

MR: Yes, you can.

GZ: He comes off stage and this fan comes up and says, "Ruby I've got to tell you, I've been to every one of your concerts." Ruby was bugged with the set. He said, "I've got to tell you man, I've been to every one of your concerts but tonight you outdid yourself." And Ruby says, "What the fuck do you know?" And he walks away.

MR: Well I'll just be brief. You know I called him for an interview, we were going to be in Sarasota Jazz Festival at the same time. And he said — he was so great on the phone. We had this half-hour conversation and I never even met him and we're laughing and stuff. And so I get down there and I seek him out and I reminded him about the interview and he let me have it.

GZ: Really?

MR: Yeah. Like what happened I don't know. I guess he was moody.

GZ: He was definitely salty you know. I love his playing though, I'll tell you, I love his playing. I think he was a very under-rated jazz player.

MR: Well let me ask you a bit about your philosophies about playing jazz. Along with the swing and the groove, talking about playing — encouraging people to play melodically.

GZ: I'm glad you brought that up because I was hoping you were going to ask that when you were posing the questions. Because I just went over this with this friend I'm teaching actually.

MR: Okay, well I've used that phrase with — most of the people I've taught over the years, like junior high, early high school age, at least in the private lessons. And I find myself saying, "Try to play melodically." And then later, after the lesson I think what do they think I mean?

GZ: They don't know what you mean.

MR: They don't know what I mean.

GZ: No Chick got me on the phone and he talked to me for 20 minutes about melody. I was surprised. Okay? His philosophy on melody. Playing the melody. In fact when I did the first take on "Skylark" I did a lot of embellishments. And he said, "Glenn, that's a beautiful tune, Hoagie Carmichael. Please play the melody on the first chorus." I was surprised. And I felt like saying, "You're telling me to play the melody? Did you ever listen to yourself?" But he has a beautiful viewpoint on melody, he really does. And he is a very melodic player. Stan Getz said this, which I think is fantastic: No matter how complex it gets you're still making a melody. Terry Gibbs told me that whatever Charlie Parker played, fast or slow, it was always a song. So this subject you're bringing up now is probably one of the most important things in jazz, and one of the things in today's jazz is completely almost lost. I had a guy tell me that he studied at Berklee and they told him, "Just get the first chorus out of the way and improvise." In other words the first chorus and the melody was something to get out of the way. This is — I told Chick that and he said, "That is so gross." You know. So, and believe me, it's hard to teach to play the melody. You've got a guy that can play all over the horn and ask them to play a song, he sounds like a student.

MR: Are there a couple of things that you can relate to people that define a good and memorable melody?

GZ: You mean in a song?

MR: In a song that perhaps could then be transferred to an improvisation.

GZ: Well when I was a kid I asked my dad how do you play jazz. And my dad was a great trumpet player, played lead trumpet like Conrad Gozzo and jazz like Louis, and he was a conductor of classical music. He said, "Just embellish the melody like Louis." And I did that. And that was [inaudible] melody like Louis. And really I wrote in the liner notes to my Charlie Parker with Strings album, I carried that philosophy of embellishing the melody even when it got more advanced like Charlie Parker, 'cause what Charlie Parker is doing is really similar to what Louis was doing just more advanced. Charlie Parker was still embellishing the melody. So I use the melody as like a guidepost to make these embellishments but it's always off the melody. It's not like they teach you in music school, patterns. That's B.S. You can't play that way and really, at a high level. Sonny Rollins said you can't think and play at the same time.

MR: Wow.

GZ: Now I know what he means by that. You can, but you hear these guys playing and I can hear them thinking okay we're going to do this pattern, that pattern, this pattern.

MR: It's like they're playing what their — they came from the practice room and they're playing it on a gig I guess.

GZ: Yeah. Yeah. That's not the way Bird played. That's not the way Coleman Hawkins played. Even though those guys know music.

MR: I feel a little —

GZ: We're going to learn everything and then forget it and just blow you know.

MR: I'm sort of sympathetic to colleges, universities that establish jazz programs. For one thing I think they need to because it's a source of income. But you can't have a four-year degree in jazz and just tell people to play by ear. Thus the codification of a lot of these things and the patterns and the books, I think they're compelled to do that because what are they going to teach for four years if they don't?

GZ: I know. I know. You have to have some kind of a methodology, right?

MR: Yeah, yes. Well you used the word — go ahead, Glenn.

GZ: You know, no go ahead, no.

MR: You used the word "empathy" and you described creation as a spiritual activity.

GZ: You know I'm amazed — you know I have a thought and then you ask me a question with the thought I have. It's just amazing how we are locking in, you and I.

MR: Good time.

GZ: I never had an interview at this level. I've been interviewed all over the world and it's been nice, but I never had anybody — I guess 'cause you're a musician yourself, to be able to lock in with my mind like this. Almost like the way I feel when I play with someone by ear.

MR: Nice.

GZ: In fact what I felt playing with Zoot. We locked in from the first note. We were thinking the same way. Anyway —

MR: So creation is a spiritual activity.

GZ: Do you agree?

MR: I do agree and this came up — normally I think when people use the word "spiritual" they think of church or religion.

GZ: Right.

MR: And I did an interview recently with Cecil McBee.

GZ: Really? Is he still alive?

MR: Yes he is and he's still teaching. And he said the same thing. Because I was asking him how does the music of jazz musicians in the 40s compare to some of the stuff he did with Pharoah Sanders in the 60s. Was it less spiritual in the 40s and more just entertainment.

GZ: I'm interested, what did he say?

MR: He said those guys back then, that was their spirit.

GZ: I'm shocked that he would — I don't know him at all, I don't even know his music. I know who he is. I'm shocked he said this, and I admire him for saying that.

MR: Yeah. I do too.

GZ: Sonny Rollins did an interview and he was talking about music being spiritual. He says, "Listen, the music comes to me, I don't know where it's coming from, I don't. I'm just the vessel for it." So I use the word aesthetic mind. Above the analytical mind, which is great for practice, great for reasoning, what you use in the mathematics let's say. There's the aesthetic mind. And that operates in a different way than the analytical mind. And that level of mind is the mind for creation. It's a higher level mind. It uses concepts, which is very related to ear playing. And forget about religion, I feel that that upper level mind, which has to do with creation, is where this music is coming from. It's not coming from thinking. You can use thinking to train yourself and practice. But when you're in the moment of creation — when Mozart was creating, I'm sure he wasn't thinking. Guaranteed. Okay?

MR: Yeah.

GZ: When Charlie Parker was playing, in the middle of a solo he wasn't thinking what change is next or what pattern goes next. Forget it. 'Cause it wouldn't come out like that. So that's what I mean when I say spiritual, meaning it's coming from a higher level — I'm not talking about God — from a higher level of the being than the normal mind.

MR: Excellent.

GZ: And painters, I'm sure even Einstein used that to come up with what he came up with, that level of mind.

MR: Does it help to have —

GZ: Does that make any sense?

MR: It does make sense and it directs my next question, if it helps — you're talking about aesthetics — do you think it helps an improvising musician to have a wide view of the world and have other interests like in other art forms?

GZ: The guys that I've studied, they do. Like Coltrane for example, his thirst for knowledge was amazing you know. So most of the — as far as I can tell the jazz musicians that I've come in contact with are extremely brilliant, they are really brilliant people. They are brilliant worldly people.

MR: Yes. I wonder if you knew Kenny Davern?

GZ: Really well. He's another Ruby Braff.

MR: Exactly. But Kenny you know —

GZ: We were traveling in the bus in the Midwest. And he said, "This is it, this is where I want to move, I'm going to open my double reed shop right here." It was in Ohio somewhere, you know.

MR: Yeah, he was a piece of work. But he could talk about anything you know. He was very well read, he just was sharp as a tack.

GZ: Musicians, jazz musicians especially, I don't know about classical musicians, I don't know that many of them, but they're brilliant. They are really smart people you know.

MR: Okay I'm going to try another question on you. We'll see if we're still linked.

GZ: How am I doing so far?

MR: You've passed the audition.

GZ: Yeah, with "Red Red Robin," right? Okay.

MR: Yeah, yeah. So earlier today I looked up the word "obsession" in the dictionary. Obsession: an idea or thought that continually preoccupies or intrudes on a person's mind. So my question is are you and have you been obsessed with music all your life?

GZ: The reverse, actually the reverse. Music was a hobby for me when I was a kid. I loved my boat, my parents were the opposite of stage parents. I had a lot of opportunity — Maynard wanted me, when I was 13 he asked my dad and my dad was making mouthpieces for him. He wanted to take me on the road as his protégé because he heard the "Ted Mack Show." So my dad politely said no, I want him to have a regular childhood. And they did. And I did. Girls, my boat, music I did gigs just to buy gasoline for my boat as a hobby. So I kind of like looked at music — it was the reverse of an obsession, believe me. And that's one of the reason — I don't want to learn chord changes, that's too hard. I'll just use my ear. I've got other things to do other than waste time learning chord changes.

MR: I love it.

GZ: You know it's like, and you know I'm trying to return to that now. I'm saying we all — you know the word "play," playing music, play. Play is play. The spirit of play. I mean these guys, you know they come on the scene, the pop guys, you know the rap guys. They want to get the Mercedes and they want to get the gig, they want to get the record deals, they want to sell merchandise — I mean it's all merchandising from day one. They haven't even got one gig yet. Whatever happened to, like I mentioned about jamming with my black friends, whatever happened just to the spirit of play? And that's what I used — I used to do that every week with [inaudible] and that's Chick Corea. "Come on over" I'd come over his house every week just to play. Sometimes it would be, a lot of it's just the two of us. He'd play vibes, he'd play drums, he'd play piano, we'd do shit

you know. And he just loved to play. Play play play. Let's play. I don't hear that today. I hear like, "Where's the next gig?" You know. I don't think I could call guys and say let's get together and play today.

MR: Speaking of playing, did you stop playing after Suzanne Somers for a while?"

GZ: Yeah I did. I did. I didn't know, I couldn't go back to jazz as usual after that. Hundred dollar gigs for 50 people, the road. I was spoiled. I was very very spoiled. And I took a break. I did a lot of real estate investing during that time. I still played you know but I just had to take a break because it was just another world that I was in you know. And then I came back, I hooked up with, I called up Irv Kratka. You know Irv?

MR: You know I met him on an elevator in New York City. I think I was going to see him, I'm not —

GZ: He's a drummer. Did you know that?

MR: I didn't know that.

GZ: I got very friendly with Irv. I didn't realize he was a fan of mine. Because you know he knew the guys. He started out, before Music Minus One he was subbing for Zutty Singleton.

MR: Oh my God.

GZ: Nick's, okay, the village? That was his background. That was his love, to play with that kind of music you know.

MR: And didn't he have Inner City Records?

GZ: He had five record labels. Inner City, Classic Jazz, yeah. So I was kind of his — I did fifteen albums for him and I fought him all the way. Because I said, Irv — I must have quit a hundred times. "Irv, I'm not a Music Minus One guy. I want to do this for my legacy, these tributes to the legends: Charlie Parker, Clifford Brown, Ben Webster." And he was in a different head but he loved the music so he let me do it. He invested about 70 grand in me. Because all those albums came out as jazz albums and they all came out as Music Minus One. But I think after him doing this since 1952 I was his exit of glory.

MR: I see.

GZ: You know what I mean? I think so.

MR: I have to remember that phrase, I might want to use that someday.

GZ: Yeah. But you met him, oh my God.

MR: Yeah.

GZ: He was a character.

MR: Here's a question, I've got to warn you, this hardly ever works.

GZ: Well okay.

MR: But I'm going to ask it anyway. Do you remember your worst gig ever?

GZ: Yeah I do. Instantly. I was doing a club date. You know what a club date is?

MR: Of course.

GZ: Okay, they call them casuals in L.A.

MR: Yeah.

GZ: And the band was terrible but a really nice guy, a bass player, I'm not going to mention his name, and I used to do a lot of — I was only maybe 15. And we get to the end of the gig, thank God it's over, and then at the last minute they come and they book the band for an hour overtime. And I freak out. This never happened to me before. And I faked an ulcer. I went up to him and I said, "Listen I've got this pain in my stomach and I can't do this." So I lied to get out of the gig, not to do the overtime. That hour would seem like death on that particular gig. So I faked an ulcer attack to get out of the gig.

MR: I've had those, I've never faked an ulcer attack, but you know I do remember those moments when you see the person who's going to pay you coming over and you know, oh don't ask me to play another hour, oh, please.

GZ: I've got another story with the same man that will really make you laugh. I'm playing a wedding in Long Island, and I play, the bride walks in and I'm playing like really affirmative, the bridal march. And I noticed that the bridal party was, the groom and the bride were kind of looking at me while I was playing but I'm playing this thing with authority. After I got done the band leader comes over and says, "My God, Glenn, do you realize you played 'Happy Birthday?'" I played [scats].

MR: Was that for aesthetic purposes?

GZ: Yeah I don't know, my God, I guess, but I played it with such authority they just kept walking.

MR: Wow.

GZ: Yeah wow.

MR: This is not the same thing, but I also play gigs as a pianist. And I've had numerous occasions where I will play a song. The first time this happened I was playing "Misty." And I wasn't jazzing it up, I was just playing "Misty." And as soon as I was done this guy comes up to me and asks me, "Hey can you play 'Misty?'" And I wonder if it's the same, I don't know, I can't imagine.

GZ: I heard a story, Woody Herman, he went to this gig down south and they forgot the dance book and he brought the concert book. And he's playing and this lady, it was a cotillion. And the lady keeps coming up and asking for some silly standard. And he's saying no. And she comes back the fourth time and he says no. And she finally says, "Do you know who I am?" Because he was refusing her. He says, "No but I know who I am, I'm not going to play that fucking song."

MR: You know that's got to —

GZ: The other thing is, those stories which are in my heart. The first time — I get a call from John Bunch, he says Benny Goodman needs a trumpet player can you come down to the Astor Hotel right away? I says sure. So I pack up my horn and I go down to the Astor Hotel, I walk in and there's Benny, Buddy Tate, John Bunch, Connie Kaye, and who's the bass player?

MR: George Duvivier.

GZ: No, the guy who sings and plays.

MR: Oh Slam Stewart?

GZ: No.

MR: Major Holley.

GZ: Major Holley. Okay. So then he doesn't say anything to me. We jam for 45 minutes. He comes up to me and he says, "I love your playing, can you leave tomorrow for the road?" Now I knew he had a trumpet player. I think it was Jack Sheldon. And I wanted to be polite, I didn't want to take someone's gig, so I said to Benny, "I thought you had a trumpet player." He said, "I didn't ask you that, can you leave tomorrow for the road?" So I leave, so I get to the gig and we're ready to go on. And I say to Connie, "Are there any charts?" Connie says, "Oh charts, yeah." He reaches into his trap case and pulls out this brown ripped piece of paper that had the last 16 bars to "Undecided" riff on it. And he hands it to me. "Here's your charts." So I get the message, there's no charts. So I go on and it's time for my feature which is "Talk of the Town." Now Benny was not known, I had a great relationship, but not known to be a very giving guy if you've heard Benny Goodman stories. Different from Count Basie. He gets on the mic he says, "Before this gentleman does his feature I want to tell you a little bit about him, this young man that I found." He says, "I've had everybody in my bands," and he starts listing all these trumpet players: Harry James, Cootie Williams, on and on. "I just want you to know before you hear him, he can hold his own with any one of those guys." I almost couldn't play after that intro.

MR: Wow. That is not the typical Benny story.

GZ: That is not — you mention Benny's name in a crowd you know you get an hour's worth, right? Now the other story is Count Basie. I did the warm-up act for Basie and I'm coming off stage and I'm walking past his dressing room, never met him, and I hear this voice, "Young man, young man, come in here." I go in and there's Count Basie. Now people don't realize that in Newark that's like walking in on Elvis or Michael Jackson, you know what I mean? He said, "I've been listening to you, you've been listening to Pops." I said, "Yeah." He said, "Well I just want to tell you something, you sound great, just keep on doing what you've been doing, don't change anything." I walked out of

there, oh my God. Count Basie takes time out of his life to call this white kid into his dressing room to validate his playing. Unbelievable. You know.

MR: Did you have things over the years, something that would occur to you that I need to know more about — I mean I'm not specifically talking about music theory now, but a particular type of, oh I need to know more Latin music, anything like that?

GZ: Well I mean I did — when I was 17 I played with all the Latin bands in New York, at the Palladium. It was a wild experience for sure. And I talked to Chick about that because Chick came up a lot, same as me, with the Latin. He worked with Mongo Santamaria you know. So, and there's a lot of influence in his playing from the Latin music, you know "Spain" and all that.

MR: Yeah.

GZ: So yeah, I had a wild experience, and it was only a couple of beboppers, it was me, Pete Yellin, do you know Pete Yellin? A couple of beboppers were doing all those gigs at the time.

MR: Tricky rhythms.

GZ: What's that? Yeah.

MR: Tricky rhythms, right?

GZ: In fact, when I first started playing with the Latin bands they would come up to me afterwards and they'd say, "You sound great but you're out of clave."

MR: You're out of —

GZ: I didn't know what the hell they're talking about. I'm just playing bebop you know? I don't know what the hell they were talking about. Do you?

MR: Yeah, I know because —

GZ: You're a teacher. I go what's clave? What is it?

MR: Yes I know that. And I know that sometimes I'll listen to the Latin music and the Latin musicians will say, "The clave's there." And I go, "Oh yeah? I can't find it." Sometimes you're thinking the three-two.

GZ: It's a real thing though, isn't it?

MR: Yeah. The clave is like [claps]. But it also can be backwards [claps].

GZ: Is it the accent of the beats? The way it's accented?

MR: Not really. It's where they're placed. The two-three clave starts with a rest, which makes it harder, I think, to like hear it and keep it in mind, but sometimes, I've been told, that in the Latin music no one is actually specifically playing the clave but it's there.

GZ: It's implied?

MR: It's implied and people are playing to it in their head, but no one is actually — like a clave can be played on a clave, right? But I've been fascinated by that music. I wish I knew more about it.

GZ: I got very friendly with the bass player at that time, a great player, very famous, Cachao. You ever hear that name?

MR: No.

GZ: He ended up moving to Miami and joining the Miami Sound Machine. He was the cat in New York. But he loved jazz and we used to jam after the gigs. It's unbelievable. This guy could play [scats] unbelievable Latin. But get him to walk four? It was funny. He could not do it.

MR: That's really funny.

GZ: He could not do it.

MR: You know this has been a fascinating conversation. I haven't asked you why you were compelled to take up the saxophone.

GZ: You know I always loved it because I was into Miles and Clifford Brown and they had — Clifford had Sonny Rollins and Miles had Coltrane and Hank Mobley. So I always was attracted to it from the trumpet records I had. So I was endorsing trumpets for LeBlanc. I was 13 years old, and I asked Vito Pascucci, I said, "Can you send me a tenor?" And he sent me a Noblet tenor and it was so — I mean it struck me now even, it was so heavy and big that's why I switched to alto. But I loved the tenor and that's how it started. I had a love for the tenor from the records that I had from Miles and Clifford Brown. No one last thing if we're at near the end, I want to tell you this moving story about Milt Hinton. You talked about Milt Hinton falling — did I tell you the story about —

MR: No I'd love to hear it.

GZ: Well we're doing the Sarasota Jazz Festival for his 80th birthday. And President Reagan sends a telegram. You know Reagan, have you ever seen that thing from the Apollo with Reagan being interviewed from the Apollo?

MR: No.

GZ: Anyway and it — he was declaring Milt Hinton Day in Jackson, Mississippi where Milt grew up. So Milt comes up to me with tears in his eyes, and he said, "I know Glenn, you the only one that really understands that" because I was very close to Milt. My grandmother was a slave in Jackson. She used to put pepper in her shoes when we were kids when they let the dogs out to chase away runaway slaves so they would sniff the pepper and run the other way. In my lifetime, because I play jazz bass, it's gone from that to this (and he showed me the telegram from Reagan). "I wish my grandma could be here to see this." And I hugged him. I mean this Black Lives Matter and all that? I grew up around all this stuff. I heard all the stories. And those guys didn't put one ounce of racism on my plate. But I heard all the stories, hanging out with them. What those guys went through, you know, was unbelievable. I mean I was good friends with Clark Terry. I subbed for Clark.

MR: Did you know Joe Wilder?

GZ: I knew Joe Wilder well. Yeah. He was getting gasoline down south. They were on tour, at a gas station. And these young guys fired guns at his feet and made him dance.

MR: Oh God.

GZ: You know. Milt told me that his aunt would drag him away but he saw hangings in the town square in Jackson where he grew up.

MR: Right.

GZ: What those guys — music to them was their only way out. We talk about the reasons to play music. Forget about what we as white people have gone through. I grew up in a middle class family. That was — I mean Coltrane, if you saw that documentary on Coltrane, to those guys this was the only chance for dignity was to be a musician.

MR: Yeah. Well I want to thank you for your time.

GZ: I want to thank you. This was — one episode is not even enough, I've got six decades worth of stuff.

MR: Yeah, we may have to do episode two and so forth. Do you have a —

GZ: I'd like to get deeper into the music with you, the melody and all that.

MR: Absolutely. Do you have any thoughts about where our country is at the moment and where it's going?

GZ: It's been, you know I don't get into politics, but the last four years have been frightening for me. And I hope that the future will be better. I hope. I mean I wouldn't want to be Joe Biden inheriting this but obviously he's not a young man and he must have some kind of passion to do it. I saw him interviewed on "The Tonight Show," this is before he decided to run, and they said are you going to run. And he said I don't know if I'm emotionally ready for it. I mean he's a completely different character than Trump, completely. As far as humility. I mean I don't know if this country — and for musicians especially, but for everybody I don't know if we're going to get back to normal. Maybe someday. What do you think? Do you think this can be repaired.

MR: I've resisted — I guess I'm an optimist and you know in the last eight months or so people are saying things like it's never going to be the same, it's never going to be the same. And I'm stubbornly refusing to embrace that just yet.

GZ: That's good. I mean America is very resilient, right?

MR: Yes. Part of it, you know I see, I have two grandkids and from what I can see they're cruising through this mess, right?

GZ: I know. I have two grandkids.

MR: Yeah.

GZ: And it's inspiring, isn't it?

MR: Yes it is. So we'll end on that note, Glenn.

GZ: Yeah, let's look to the children to lead the way maybe, huh?

MR: Yes indeed.

GZ: But I've got to be honest, I'm a little worried what they're walking into that they're not fully aware of. You know. But youth is youth, no?

MR: And I was going to say, you packed your youth with an awful lot of things.

GZ: I did. I was fortunate. Listen I've been blessed, no doubt about it. I had a musical family and I've been blessed. And I did pack my youth with a lot of things. And I'm still continuing. You know I was thinking that maybe it's time to hang it up you know. I've had a glorious career but I'm enjoying — I'm busier than ever with Chick and this guitar, do you know this guy Romero Lubambo?

MR: I heard, you recorded something with him?

GZ: Yes he was four years with Astrud Gilberto and he was 15 years with Dianne Reeves, a beautiful player. So we did three singles and I have this guy in India. So I'm having a good time adventuring into new territory with the Indian music.

MR: Good.

GZ: But my love is what we're talking about. My love is for the classic. And I'm not talking about — you know I heard a good interview with Steve Swallow. He said a beautiful thing. He said when he first moved to New York he was working at the same time with Paul Bley and at Nick's with Dixieland guys. And he said a beautiful — with what's his name the clarinet player, Pee Wee Russell. And he said a beautiful thing, he said you know those guys at Nick's that I was playing with, I can't say enough about them. They're all ear players but they had special qualities that were so evident, these ear players, that were so different than everybody else I was playing with in the modern world. And I gave him credit for saying that.

MR: Well on that note I'm going to pause our recording and then we'll say good-bye, all right?

GZ: Fair enough.

MR: All right.